



No return in sight: Sunil Narine's spectacular form this IPL season ignited chatter about his return to the national fold for the T20 World Cup. But the allrounder has ruled out any such possibility. K. R. DEEPAK

Indies, though, has tried to strike a balance between the two. Shimron Hetmyer has been named in West Indies' 15-man squad for the 2024 T20 World Cup. Shamar Joseph, the 24-year-old fast bowler who has played only three T20s and is yet to make his international debut in the

format, has also been called up. Desmond Haynes, West Indies' chairman of selectors, said Shamar's selection was role-specific. "You really can't question Shamar Joseph's skills," Haynes said. "You saw him in Australia. We were looking at someone up front bowling the first

PowerPlay, and he ticked the boxes." Shamar is one of several West Indies players in the IPL. Lucknow Super Giants signed him as a replacement player. However, he had a tough debut against Kolkata Knight Riders, conceding 47 runs. So far, he has played three T20s and has yet to take a wicket while conceding 9.91 runs per over.

Hetmyer's return is big news for West Indies, especially considering that selectors picked him for the finisher's role.

In the last two IPL seasons, Hetmyer has smashed 383 runs off 192 balls at the death while striking at 199.48 — taking down left-arm and right-arm pace with equal disdain, going north of 200 against both styles of bowling. This year too, Hetmyer's strike rate between overs 17 and 20 is upwards of 200. The mere thought of Hetmyer and Russell teeing off simultaneously should be enough to make bowling attacks shudder.

Given that bowling is likely to be West Indies' weaker suit, the toss will once again be crucial. Historically, West Indies has preferred chasing. In

ONE OF THE CRITICISMS AIMED AT THE WEST INDIES CRICKET TEAM, PARTICULARLY IN T20IS, HAS BEEN ITS ONE-DIMENSIONAL FOCUS ON POWER-HITTING

2016, West Indies won six tosses out of six and chose to bowl every time; in 2021 it lost four tosses out of five, and was sent in to bat every time. Last World Cup, it won three tosses out of three and chose to bat twice.

While boundaries may still be the primary grammar of the T20 format, it's the bowling that could ultimately decide West Indies' fate.

A record third T20 world title is theirs to grab — the question, as always, is just how badly do the men from the Caribbean want it.